

Relationship Mines

Relationships are born out of interactions and communications. When you talk to a neighbour, when you forward that funny e-mail to 20 of your friends, or send a project update to a client, your relationships are being nurtured. Electronic communications are forming the most used pathways to your friends and associates, and inevitably that leaves a trail of electronic conversations.

How would you react to software that wants to watch this conversation? It is initially counter-intuitive, but your relationships have huge latent value to everyone involved in them that may not be fully used.

Social software that try to mine your relationships, and create a visible network of your links to people around you, are all the rage. Services such as LinkedIn, Spoke and Friendster, all offer different perspectives on the same basic theme—you may know someone who is important to someone else, and someone you know, could introduce you to an important person.

But all these software fail to account for the variability in strength and quality of the relationships. Not everyone in your address book is equally well-connected to you. There may be imbalances in relationships, where you feel it is stronger or weaker than it really is. These services try to classify relationships, by asking you to pick from a list of predefined labels, but that can be too limiting in scope.

Building and maintaining relationships is a sustained effort that requires grace and empathy—precisely the qualities that are hard to be captured by software. All these services are in the first generation, and bound to be simplistic; but it is inevitable that as the power of mining these networks becomes apparent, inferring and capturing nuances of relationships will be top priority.

The emergence of such social software is an interesting pointer to the kind of assistance that can be expected from computers in the near future; very different from the direct unintelligent task-solution based approach of, say, a word-processor. Software that intelligently sorts your e-mails, intelligently classifies your relationships, infers what information you are looking for, and generally observes and does what you do, are just over the horizon!



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